

The Confederate commanders, however, had already decided that their position was hopeless. Floyd decided to attempt a breakout that would enable his force to rejoin General Albert S. Johnston at Nashville. The bulk of the defenders, under Brigadier General Gideon Pillow, were concentrated in front of McClernand's division on the Union right, and at dawn on February 15 they attacked with their blood-chilling rebel yell. By chance, Grant had left to consult with Foote some way down river. With no one to coordinate a Union response, McClernand's troops were driven back, taking heavy casualties. The Confederate cavalry, under Colonel Nathan Bedford Forrest, distinguished itself in a series of flanking attacks. For the Union side, Brigadier General Lew Wallace (future author of *Ben Hur*) reinforced the flank and held a vital hill line.

The opportunity was there for Pillow to complete the breakout, but, shocked by the condition of his troops, he withdrew back to the trenches. When Grant arrived at the battle, he pointed out to his badly shaken officers that if many of their own troops were demoralized, the Confederates, having fallen back, must be even more so. Grant ordered an assault on the center of the Confederate line, which he reasoned must have been weakened to provide troops for the flank breakout. Colonel James Tuttle's 2nd Iowa Regiment duly penetrated the Confederate defenses, while, on the right, Wallace regained all the ground lost earlier in the day. That night, in a rush to save their own troops, Floyd and Pillow slipped away under cover of darkness. Forrest escaped with 700 troopers by riding through the Union lines. Command devolved to Brigadier General Simon Bolivar Buckner. The next morning, Buckner's request for terms was met by Grant's demand for "immediate surrender." Buckner had no choice but to comply, passing into captivity along with more than 12,000 other Confederate soldiers.